

The Rich Report

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U.S. ECONOMICS NEWS

- **Petroleum Surplus:** The U.S. recorded its largest petroleum trade surplus in 30 years in April 2026, marking 50 consecutive months as a net exporter of petroleum products; while the U.S. remains a net crude oil importer due to refinery configurations, large-scale exports of refined products like gasoline, diesel, and propane more than offset that gap.³
- **Housing Stagnation:** Existing home sales rose 3.2% in May to a 4.17 million annual rate — the fastest pace of 2026 — but the figure masks a deeper problem: sales have been stuck near 4 million for three years, roughly matching post-2008 crisis lows and far below the pre-COVID norm of 5.25 million, with affordability eroded by Iran War-driven energy inflation pushing 30-year mortgage rates to 6.6%.³
- **War Inflation:** May CPI rose 0.5%, pushing the annual rate to 4.2% — the highest since early 2023 — with energy accounting for more than half the monthly increase as gasoline jumped 7.0%; core CPI, at 2.9% annually, remains well above the Fed's 2% target, though it came in below expectations at 0.2% for the month, suggesting non-energy price pressures are more contained.³
- **Wage Erosion:** Real inflation-adjusted average hourly earnings fell 0.1% in May and are down 0.7% over the past year, meaning workers are losing purchasing power despite nominal wage growth; consumers have so far offset the squeeze through tax refunds and a declining savings rate, but analysts warn this buffer is unlikely to last if energy costs remain elevated.³
- **Pipeline Pressure:** May PPI surged 1.1% — double the consensus estimate — driven by a 10.7% spike in energy prices and a record 2.8% monthly jump in goods prices, the largest since the series began in 2009; upstream pressure is even more acute, with unprocessed intermediate goods up 22.2% year-over-year, signaling that energy-driven cost increases are still working their way through supply chains.³
- **Warsh Era:** The Federal Reserve holds its first meeting under new Chair Kevin Warsh this week, with markets pricing near-zero probability of a rate move; Warsh is expected to push for an end to "forward guidance" and may reshape the dot plot process, while a broader debate over whether AI-driven productivity gains — which have run at a 2.7% annual rate over the past three years — could allow the Fed to hold rates lower without stoking inflation remains unresolved.³

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DIGITAL ASSETS NEWS

- **Citi on Flows:** In a quantitative analysis of market dynamics, Citi found that weekly net flows into spot bitcoin ETFs account for approximately 45% of BTC's weekly price variance — a stronger explanatory relationship than any other single variable. This makes ETF flow data the most reliable real-time signal for tracking genuine institutional and retail investor adoption of bitcoin as an asset class.⁵
- **White House July 4 Push:** White House crypto adviser Patrick Witt revealed the administration has set an ambitious Independence Day deadline for House passage of the Clarity Act, the landmark legislation designed to establish a comprehensive regulatory framework for digital assets. The target reflects growing urgency within the administration to deliver on crypto policy promises and provide long-awaited legal certainty to the industry.⁵
- **SEC Strategic Plan (FY2026–2030):** The SEC's Draft Strategic Plan elevates digital assets and distributed ledger technology to its foremost regulatory priority under Goal 1 — a significant shift signaling the agency's intent to build a formal, forward-looking framework for crypto markets. This marks the first time digital assets have anchored the SEC's multi-year strategic agenda, reflecting both industry growth and persistent investor protection concerns.⁵
- **JPMorgan on Clarity Act:** JPMorgan analysts highlighted the long-awaited Clarity Act as a potential inflection point for U.S. crypto markets, arguing its passage would resolve years of jurisdictional ambiguity between the SEC and CFTC, lower compliance barriers for institutional participants, and meaningfully accelerate the tokenization of real-world assets — a sector JPMorgan itself has been actively building infrastructure to support.⁵
- **SpaceX IPO & BTC:** When SpaceX made its long-awaited Nasdaq debut on June 12 at a record \$350 billion valuation, it quietly introduced Wall Street to something unprecedented: 18,712 BTC (~\$1.29 billion) sitting on its balance sheet — the largest bitcoin treasury ever carried into a public offering, signaling that institutional-grade crypto holdings are becoming a standard feature of major corporate listings.⁵

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GEOPOLITICS NEWS

- **Canada:** Ottawa introduced legislation that could bar children under 16 from social media unless platforms prove they can keep them safe, joining a growing global push. A new Digital Safety Commission would enforce rules covering seven types of harmful content, including material inciting self-harm or violence.¹
- **Canada:** At Washington's request, Ottawa delayed opening the multibillion-dollar Gordie Howe bridge linking Detroit and Windsor. Prime Minister Carney downplayed any link to trade tensions, citing "technical issues," though Trump had earlier threatened to hold up the launch unless the US received a 50% ownership stake and compensation "for everything we have given" Canada.¹
- **Europe:** Only 11% of Europeans now consider the United States an ally, a historic low, down from 16% six months ago and 22% when Trump won in 2024, per a European Council on Foreign Relations survey.¹
- **Europe:** At least six supertankers carrying roughly 12 million barrels of UAE and Omani crude are due in Europe next month, an unusual flow driven by China sharply cutting its own purchases during the Iran war.¹
- **European Union:** A decade-in-the-making asylum and migration overhaul took effect Friday, bringing stricter border controls, faster case processing, expanded digital tracking and more deportations.¹
- **Iran:** The US and Iran announced an interim deal to halt nearly four months of fighting and reopen the Strait of Hormuz, with signing expected Friday. Mediator Pakistan said both sides declared a "permanent termination of military operations on all fronts, including in Lebanon." Several details remain unresolved, and hardliners on
- **Lebanon:** Israel struck a Hezbollah target on the outskirts of Beirut, an escalation Trump said "should not have happened" as he urged restraint. The attack complicated framework peace talks, since Iran insists any deal extend to Lebanon. Fighting there began after Hezbollah fired on Israel in solidarity with Tehran; neither party is in the negotiations.¹
- **South Korea:** Seoul and the EU held their first summit in three years to deepen trade, tech and defense ties, planning a competitiveness partnership and signing a digital trade deal.¹
- **United States:** A US drone boat pulled off a first-of-its-kind sea rescue, recovering the two-person crew of an Apache helicopter that crashed near the Strait of Hormuz after two hours in the water.¹
- **United States:** The House narrowly passed, 214-212, nearly \$70 billion to fund immigration enforcement for three years, sending it to Trump. The bill front-loads money for ICE and Border Patrol to support deporting about a million people annually.¹

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THE GOOD NEWS

- **Diamond Cooling:** Lab-grown diamonds, traditionally a jewelry product, are gaining traction as heat spreaders in AI chips, outperforming copper and aluminum in managing thermal loads from densely packed semiconductors. Several Chinese producers have begun commercial shipments after clients validated the material, reflecting a broader industry search for next-generation cooling solutions as AI hardware demands intensify.²
- **Grid Modernization:** Federal regulators approved PJM Interconnection's expedited track for large power plant connections, helping fast-lane new generation capacity to meet surging U.S. electricity demand — which hit record highs in both 2024 and 2025 — driven by AI data centers and electrification. The streamlined process allows up to 10 large projects annually to advance quickly with state-level siting support.²
- **Cleaner Water:** A large-scale analysis of 266 million water quality readings across 48 states found U.S. drinking water pollution fell by half between 2003 and 2019, largely driven by Safe Drinking Water Act loans to municipal water systems. Those investments proved highly cost-effective at roughly \$46 per person annually and measurably reduced mortality rates among older Americans.²

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DIVIDEND PORTFOLIO NEWS

- **ABT:** Declared a \$0.63 quarterly dividend. Abbott was also flagged in a bullish healthcare basket update by Citrini Research, suggesting renewed upside potential in the sector.⁴
- **BKH:** Upgraded to Buy at Bank of America, citing data center value creation opportunity. The company is pressing forward with its Wyoming data center project despite anchor tenant Crusoe Energy pulling out.⁴
- **CAT:** Raised its quarterly dividend 7.9% to \$1.63 per share, reflecting continued confidence in earnings power and cash generation.⁴
- **CL:** Declared a \$0.53 quarterly dividend, consistent with its Dividend King track record.⁴
- **LMT:** Secured a \$2.293B F-35 long-term sustainment contract, a \$514.4M space vehicle contract modification, and a \$153.9M deal for F-35 long-lead parts. Patriot missile demand is outpacing supply globally, and the Pentagon is pushing a low-cost missile expansion strategy — both favorable demand signals for Lockheed's defense portfolio.⁴
- **NTR:** Despite the U.S.-Iran peace deal reopening the Strait of Hormuz, analysts cautioned that fertilizer shipments may not benefit quickly due to logistical and contract complexities beyond the strait itself.⁴
- **QCOM:** Participated in the broad semiconductor rally driven by the U.S.-Iran peace deal and AI momentum. Also announced collaborations with SDG&E and Scripps on AI wildfire detection, and with SLB on edge AI for energy operations, expanding its industrial AI footprint.⁴

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GROWTH PORTFOLIO NEWS

- **COIN:** Coinbase launched an agentic trading and payments tool and partnered with MassPay for stablecoin-powered cross-border payouts — expanding its fintech reach. Crypto stocks broadly climbed as Bitcoin held near two-week highs post-Hormuz deal. The Clarity Act crypto legislation remains stalled, with experts calling a July 4 breakthrough "impossible."⁴
- **CVX:** Energy shares fell sharply Monday as the Iran-US peace deal reduced oil disruption risk and prospects for Strait of Hormuz reopening pressured prices. Persian Gulf flows were already running ~7M bbl/day with US escorts. Separately, Chevron signed contracts with YPF for an Argentina shale NGL venture, adding downstream optionality.⁴
- **HOOD:** Robinhood saw a surge in app downloads tied to SpaceX's historic IPO, where it served as a key retail platform — though customers faced technical issues in the first minutes of SpaceX trading. CEO Vlad Tenev confirmed Robinhood is now approved as an underwriter, signaling ambitions to disrupt traditional IPO access. Cathie Wood sold HOOD shares to fund SpaceX.⁴
- **MRVL:** Marvell hired Adobe CFO Durn as its new CFO and reaffirmed Q2 guidance — a meaningful leadership and confidence signal. The stock was caught in mid-week chip sector selling tied to AI trade unwinding, though it trended positively on SpaceX IPO week sentiment.⁴
- **NVDA:** Nvidia is raising at least \$20B via a bond offering, one of the largest ever in tech. It's pitching Vera CPUs to Chinese clients with orders set for August. KKR, Nvidia, and Vistra jointly launched an infrastructure company targeting hyperscalers. Goldman Sachs flagged AI spending could pressure Big Tech returns longer-term. Nvidia also hired a former Obama official to lead government affairs and partnered with healthcare AI startup Abridge.⁴
- **SYF:** Synchrony Financial is on watch as the Federal Reserve will release bank stress test results June 24 — a key near-term catalyst for consumer finance stocks.⁴
- **TOL:** Toll Brothers and homebuilder stocks climbed Monday as the Iran-US peace deal led traders to lower rate hike bets, improving the interest-rate-sensitive housing sector's near-term outlook.⁴
- **TSM:** TSMC reported May revenue up 30% year-over-year on strong AI chip demand. A potential Google-Samsung TPU manufacturing deal raised concerns about customer diversification away from TSMC. US senators pushed for tighter rules on contract chipmakers supplying China-linked overseas entities — a regulatory risk for TSMC's global operations.⁴
- **VST:** Vistra joined Nvidia and KKR in launching a new infrastructure company targeting hyperscale data center customers, positioning the power generator at the intersection of AI infrastructure buildout.⁴

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S U M M A R Y

In regard to the United States Economy, energy costs from the war with Iran drove the data. Consumer prices rose to a 4.2% annual rate in May, the highest since early 2023, with gasoline up 7.0%. Producer prices surged and real wages slipped over the year. Home sales remain near multi-decade lows as mortgage rates hover around 6.6%. The Federal Reserve, now under new Chair Kevin Warsh, is expected to hold rates steady.

In the world of digital assets, regulation and institutional adoption took center stage. Analysts found that flows into spot bitcoin exchange-traded funds now explain nearly half of bitcoin's weekly price movement, the clearest signal yet of mainstream demand. Washington is pushing landmark market-structure legislation, with regulators elevating digital assets to a top priority, though analysts doubt a July passage. Meanwhile, a record-breaking technology listing revealed more than 18,000 bitcoin on its balance sheet.

Recently around the globe, the war between the United States and Iran dominated headlines before the two sides reached an interim deal to halt fighting and reopen the Strait of Hormuz. The conflict kept energy and fertilizer markets on edge. Israel escalated strikes in Lebanon, while Ukraine pressed deep attacks on Russian refineries and ports. Europe wrestled with defense spending and migration, and a rightward shift continued across Latin America.

For the good news, technology and infrastructure offered encouraging signs. Lab-grown diamonds are emerging as superior heat spreaders for artificial-intelligence chips, outperforming copper and aluminum as producers begin commercial shipments. Federal regulators approved a faster track for connecting large power plants, helping meet record electricity demand driven by data centers. And a sweeping study found that drinking-water pollution across the country fell by half over sixteen years, cost-effectively reducing mortality among older Americans.

In the news for the dividend portfolio, several holdings rewarded shareholders and advanced strategic priorities. Caterpillar raised its dividend nearly eight percent, while Abbott and Colgate-Palmolive declared steady quarterly payouts. A utility holding was upgraded on the strength of its data-center opportunity. Lockheed Martin secured several billion dollars in new defense contracts amid surging missile demand, and Qualcomm joined a broad semiconductor rally while expanding partnerships in artificial-intelligence applications across energy and public safety.

And, for the growth portfolio, the Iran peace deal reshaped trading: energy names fell as oil-disruption risk eased, while homebuilders, chipmakers, and crypto-linked stocks climbed. Nvidia launched a massive bond sale and joined a new artificial-intelligence infrastructure venture, as Taiwan Semiconductor reported revenue up thirty percent on chip demand. Coinbase and Robinhood expanded into payments and public offerings, the latter riding a landmark technology listing, while several holdings positioned around the data-center buildout.

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RESOURCES



1. Research accumulated from <https://www.patreon.com/cw/PeterZeihan>, <https://x.com/>, and <https://seekingalpha.com/>
2. <https://newsletter.humanprogress.org/>
3. Research accumulated from <https://www.ftportfolios.com/> and <https://bravosresearch.com/research/>
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